

How are children doing these days?



T/Th 9:35-10:25am

Professor Casey Lew-Williams

Kennedy Casey, Abby Fergus, Sarah Joo, Chantal Valdivia, Claire Whiting

Go share your thoughts
(or links/photos/videos)
on a google slide...



How did I become interested in developmental science?



I care first and foremost
about how we treat children.

There are many ways to think about
children's wellbeing.

ManyBabies

A global consortium of developmental researchers



A team of 719 scientists from 287 institutions in 54 countries on 6 continents working on collaborative studies of infants' learning and development.

ManyBabies has opened my eyes to research questions from around the globe.

Children are a vulnerable population.

How are they doing these days?

Many, many children are doing well!



There are many positive trends

Decline in child mortality.

Decline in child marriages.

Small increases in school attendance and literacy.

Increased access to clean water.

More girls are completing secondary school.

More school meals for children.

1. Policies

I keep one eye on policies that help children,
and one eye on the hidden agenda behind them.

Do you trust grownups to make good decisions?

‘Trump Accounts’

In the ‘big, beautiful bill’, the federal government is planning to create a \$1,000 savings account for each baby born between 2025 and 2028.

This could help families start saving early.

“Trump Accounts”

- An American child born after December 31, 2024 and before January 1, 2029 for whom a Trump Account is established will receive an initial \$1,000 deposit from the government, with the potential for parents to contribute up to an additional \$5,000 per year initially.
 - Employers may make an annual contribution of up to \$2,500 to a Trump Account and that contribution will not impact the employee’s taxable income.
- CEA estimates that, under a scenario of average returns on the U.S. stock market, Trump Account balance for a baby born in 2026 will be:
 - \$303,800 by age 18 and \$1,091,900 by age 28 if maximum contributions are made.
 - \$5,800 by age 18 and \$18,100 by age 28 if no contributions are made.

USAID



In early 2025, the very first political pet project of Elon Musk,
the richest human being on Earth,

was to shut down a global program that saves
the poorest human beings on Earth.

We should ask ourselves:
How is this possible?

2. Research Funding



Total Number of
Impacted Grants
5124



Number of
Reinstated Grants
1361



Current Loss from
Impacted Grants
\$4.52B



Total Number of
Impacted Grants
1984



Number of
Reinstated Grants
430



Current Loss from
Impacted Grants
\$0.97B



3. Moms

Many countries have social safety nets.
The U.S. has women.



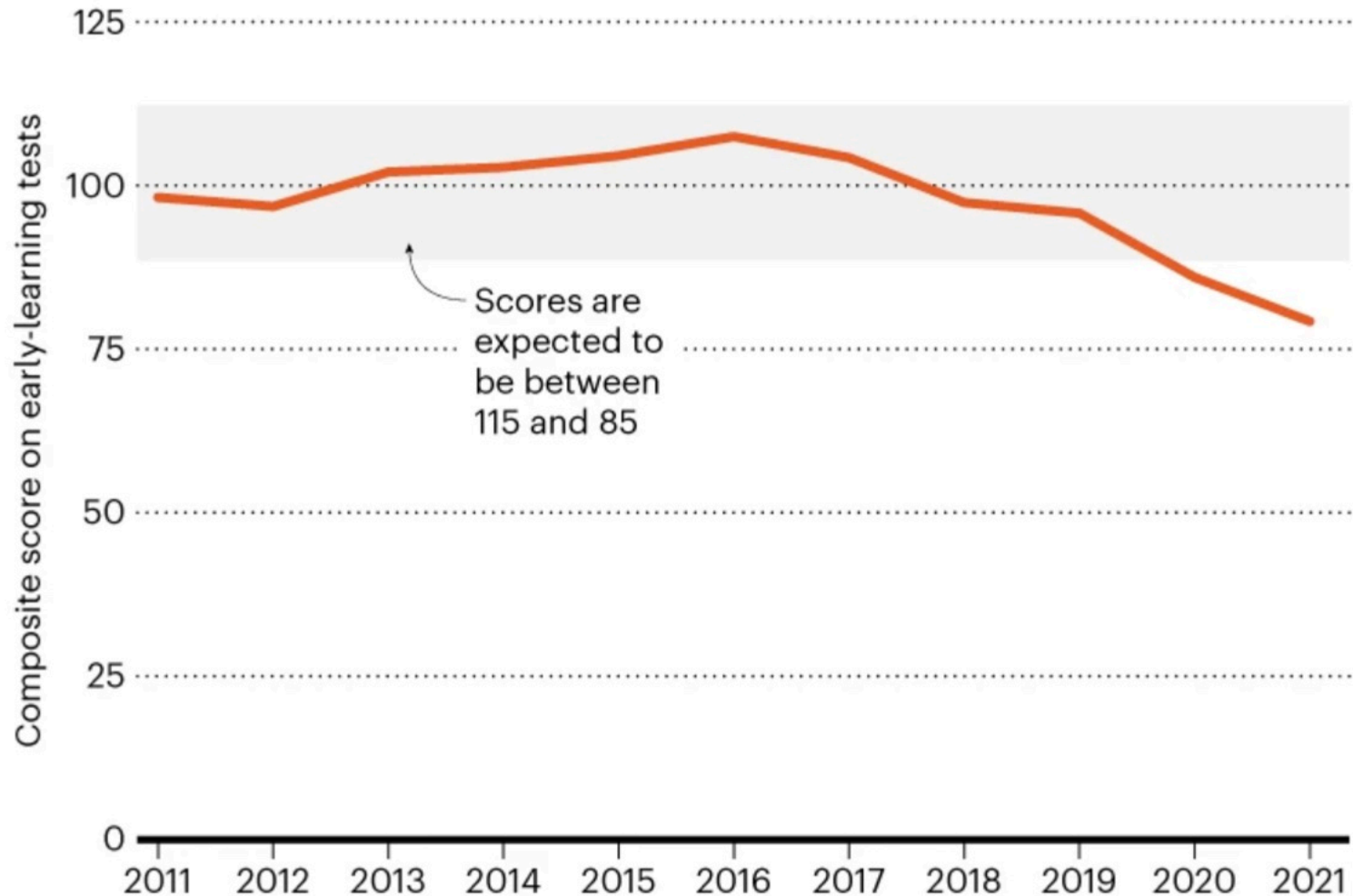
4. COVID-19

COVID-19 was the world's most drastic experiment.

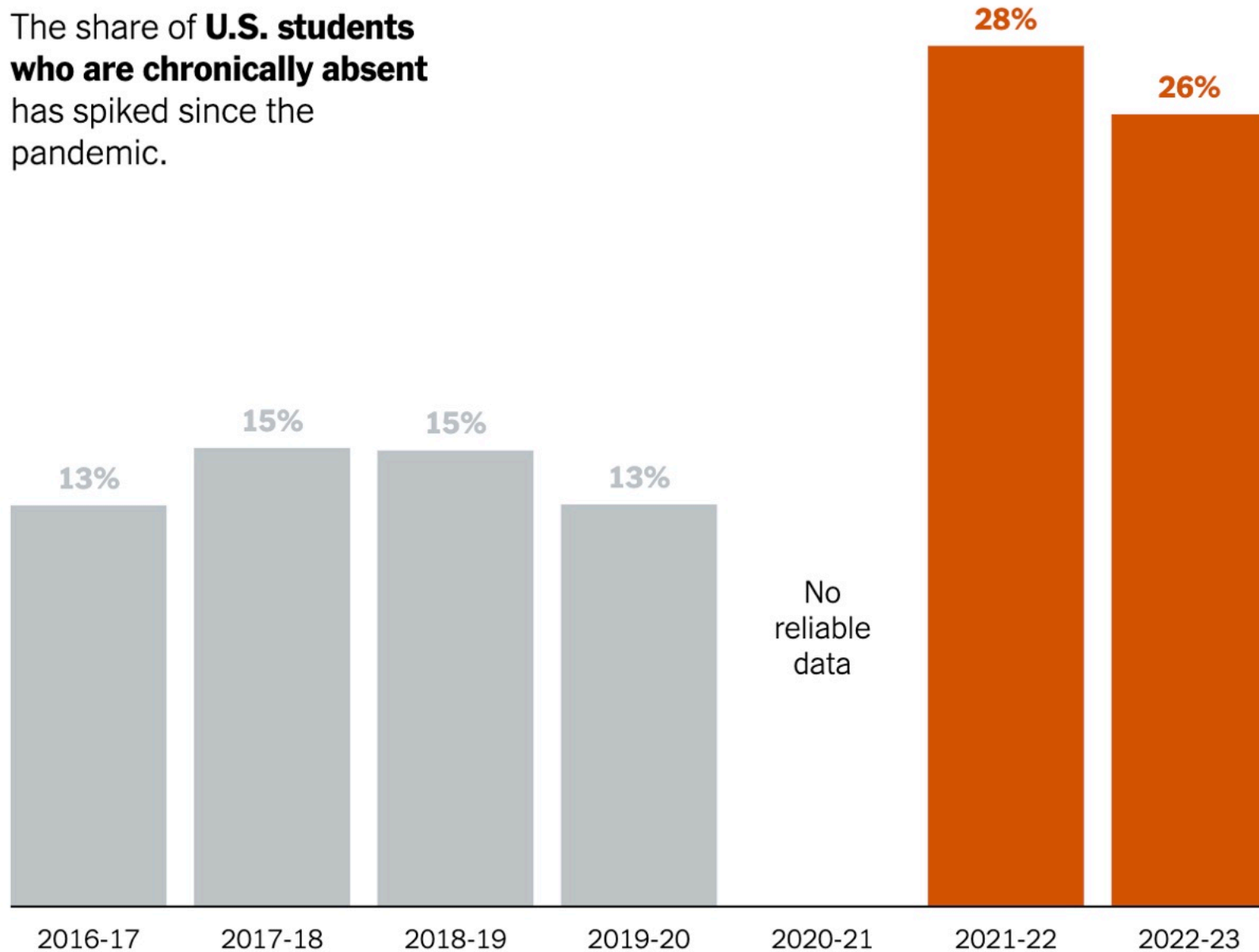
The education gap became a gulf.

DEVELOPMENT DIP

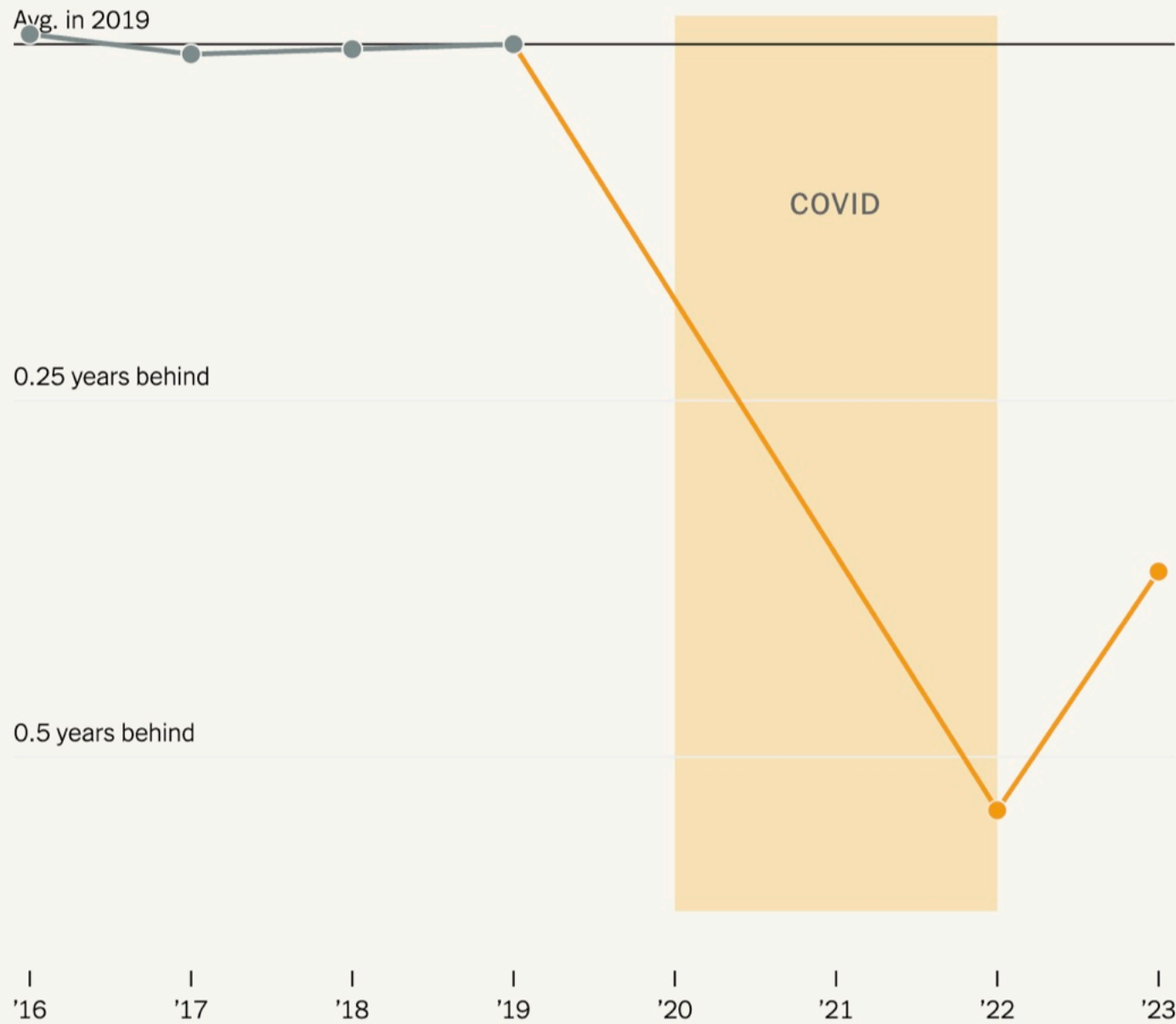
Researchers tested the cognitive performance of more than 600 children aged 3 months to 3 years, including 39 babies born during the COVID-19 pandemic. On average, those assessed in 2020 and 2021 scored lower on tests of early learning, including language, puzzle-solving and motor skills such as standing and walking.



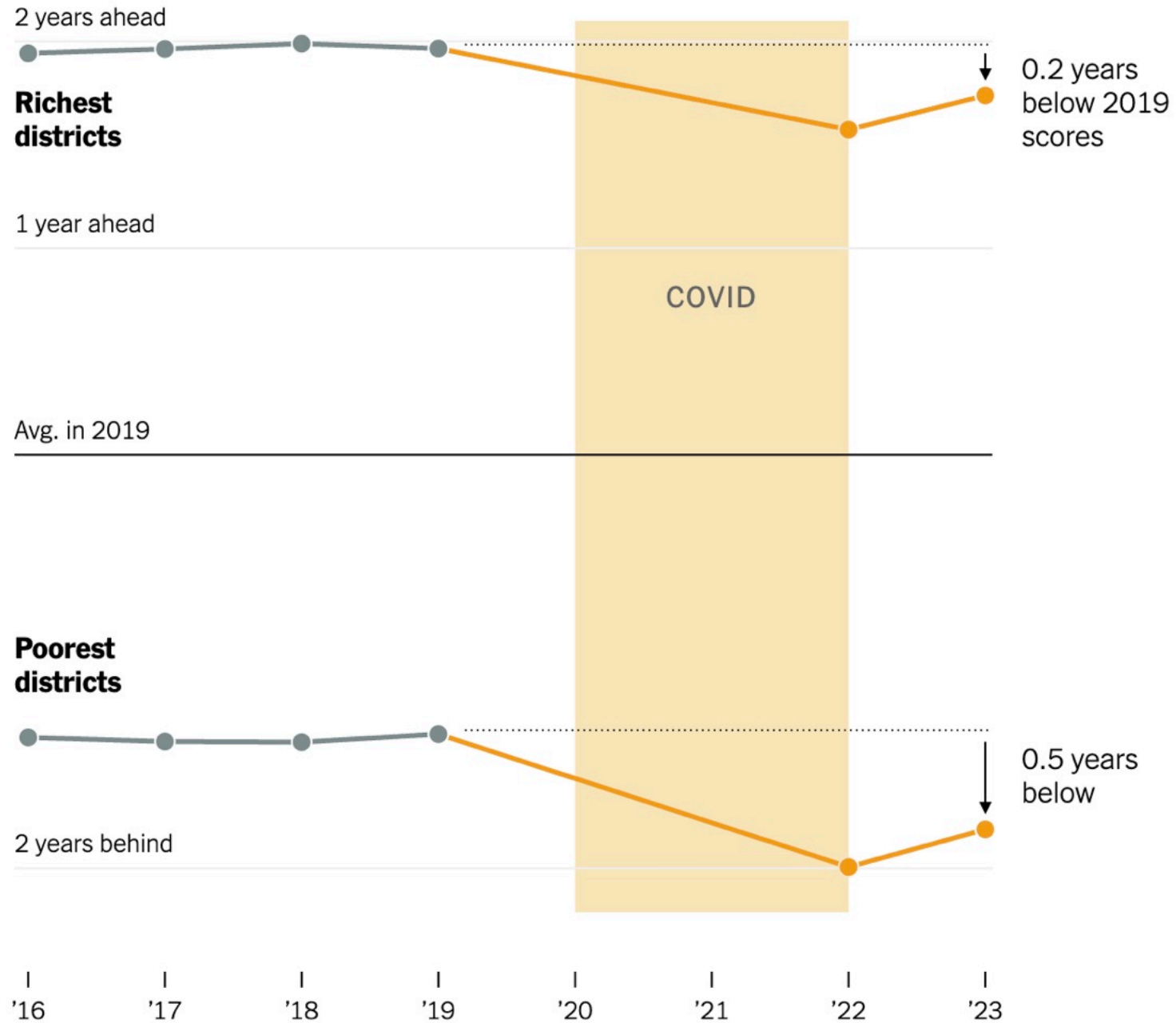
The share of **U.S. students who are chronically absent** has spiked since the pandemic.



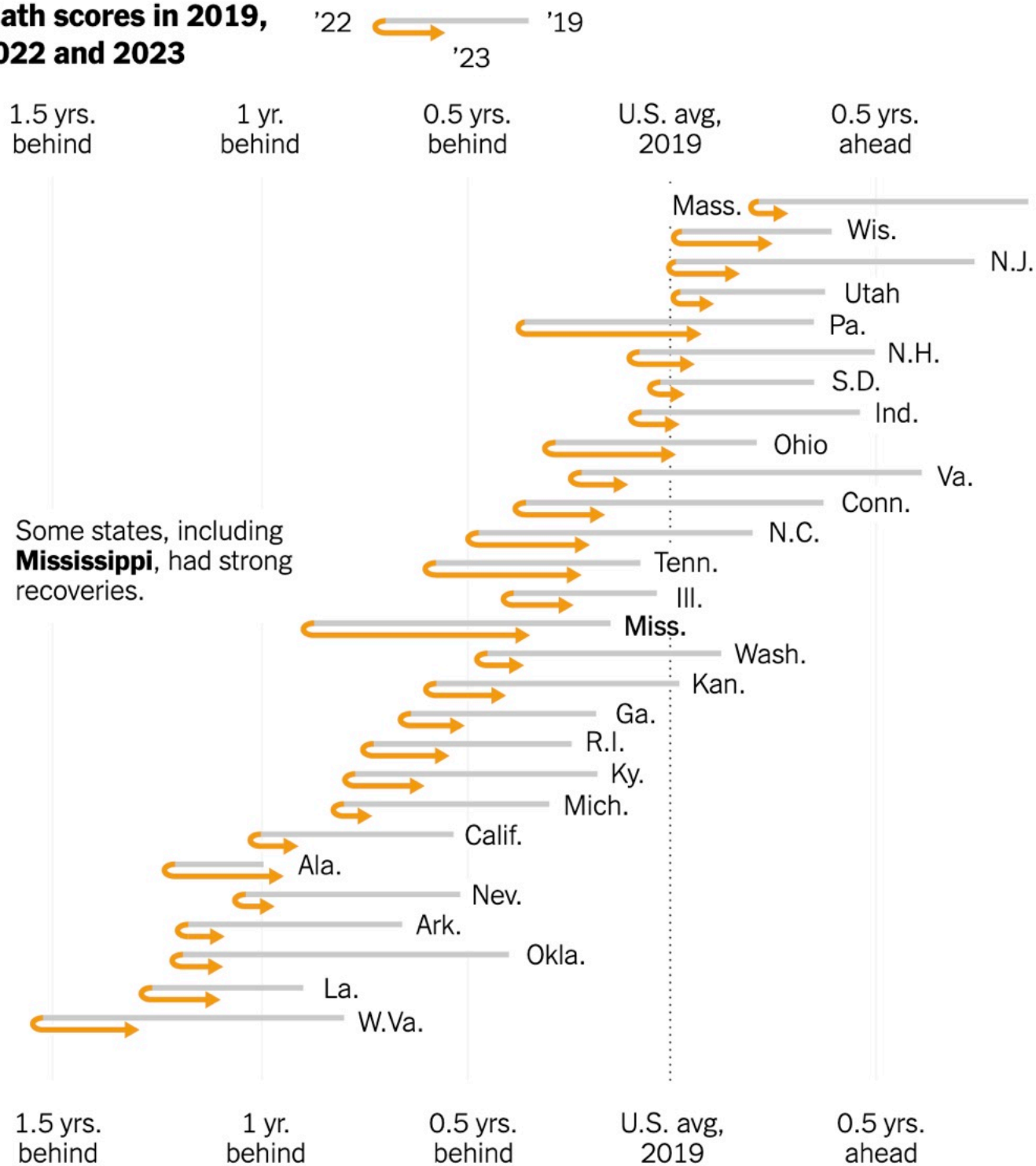
Math scores, 3rd grade through 8th



Math test scores, 3rd grade through 8th



Math scores in 2019, 2022 and 2023



<https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2023/05/11/opinion/pandemic-learning-losses-steep-but-not-permanent.html?smid=nytcore-ios-share&referringSource=articleShare>

“...the educational impacts of the pandemic were not driven solely by what was happening (or not happening) in schools. The disruption in children’s lives outside of school also mattered: the constriction of their social lives, the stress their parents were feeling, the death of family members, the signals that the world was not safe and the very real fear that you or someone you love might get very sick and die. The pandemic was a public health and economic disaster that reshaped every area of children’s lives, but it did so to different degrees in different communities, and so its consequences for children depended on where they lived.”

5. Child labor

138 million children are engaged in child labor globally.
54 million do hazardous work.

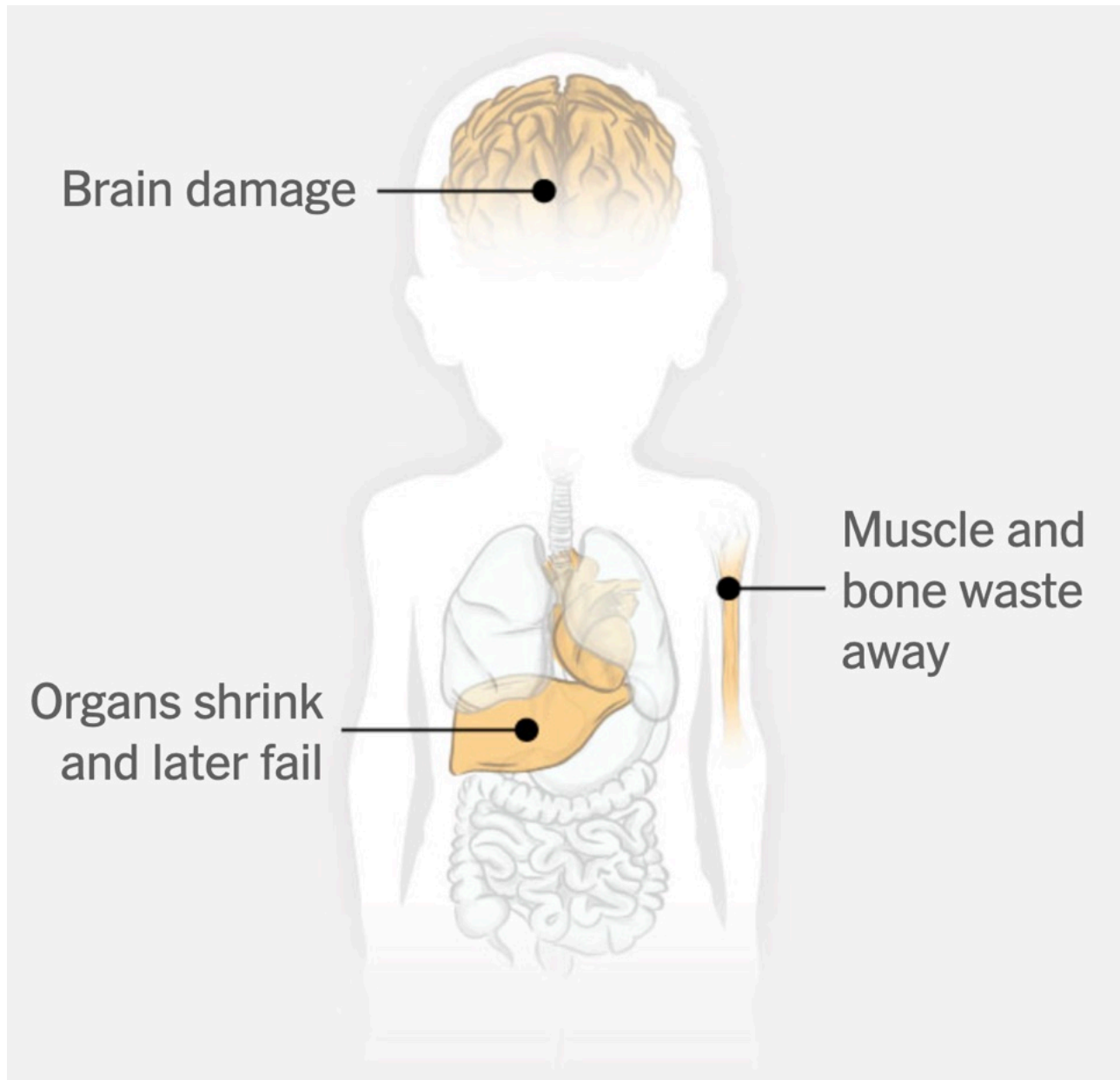
Common jobs: agriculture, street vending, domestic work,
manufacturing.

This is an improvement since 2020, and since 2000.

To achieve elimination, we need improvement to be 11x
faster.

6. Malnutrition

320 million people have limited access to food worldwide.
2 million are gripped by catastrophic hunger and on the
brink of famine, mostly in Gaza and Sudan.



7. Gun violence

U.S. children are 80% more likely to die (from ages 1 to 19) than their peers in other high-income countries.

Risk of firearm-related death is 15x greater.

8. Developmental delays and disorders

In many parts of the world,
I feel concern for young kids
who are at risk for developmental delays.

Positive trends: increased awareness and
advocacy; inclusive education; early
intervention; better protections.

9. Environmental degradation

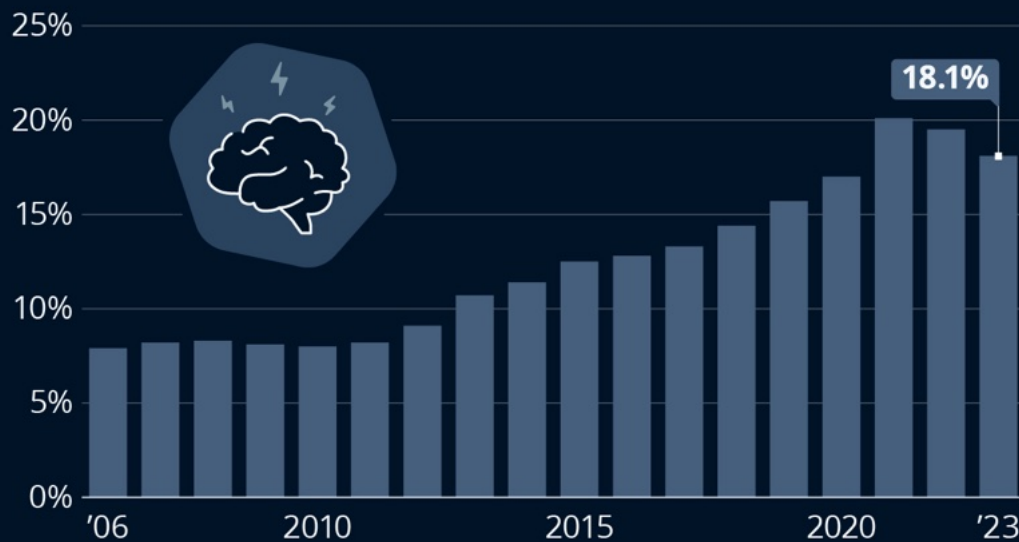
Why are children more vulnerable than adults?

- Pollutants enter their bodies more easily
- Effects accumulate over decades
- Less physiological/psychological reserve
- Children depend on adults and governments. They cannot choose different environments.
- Climate-driven disasters disproportionately uproot families with young children (from school, from social stability)
- They inherit ecological crises they did not create.

10. Mental health

Nearly One in Five U.S. Teens Experienced Depression in 2023

Share of U.S. teenagers (12-17 y/o) who have experienced a major depressive episode in the past year*



* More than 14,000 respondents per year

Source: Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration



statista

LGBTQ+ youth face many challenges
in the U.S. and abroad.

Children are resilient.

What articles did you read?

What did you find interesting?



60 million readers across 65 countries

32,000 views per article

5,000 scientists have published (& 33 Nobel laureates)

10,000 kids have served as reviewers

We want young people
to imagine and create
new ways of living and being.

As a grownup, how are you
going to encourage this?

